GC Telecom: 5G Sep BTS deployment MoM increased; Fiber cable exports show strong YoY growth

Allen Chang
+852-2978-2930 | allen.k.chang@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C.

Verena Jeng
+852-2978-1681 | verena.jeng@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C.

Ting Song
+852-2978-6466 | ting.song@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C.

5G base station deployment in Sep 2026 was 59k units, at 0% YoY, leading to an accumulated base station deployment of 5.3mn units as of Sep 2026. Newly added 5G base stations stood at 416k units in 9M26, tracking at 77% of our estimate for new 5G base stations in 2026E (vs. 9M tracking at 71% of new 5G base stations in 2025). **Base station production was down 51% YoY in Sep 2026, and export volumes maintained strong momentum:** 1) China's telecom service industry revenue was up 1% YoY in August to Rmb140bn (per MIIT); 2) new 5G base station deployment stayed flattish in Sep 2026 to 59k units, vs. 59k units added in Sep 2025; and 3) 5G subscriber growth accelerated MoM, to +8mn in Aug 2026, vs. +17mn in Aug 2025. Export values of BTS, PCB, CCL, and fiber cables all saw positive YoY growth in Sept 2026, indicating strong overseas demand. Read more: Review of China telcos' 10 key metrics.

Key data points in Sep 2026

5G base station deployment increased YoY: Sep 2026 5G base station deployment was 59k units, vs. 59k in Sep 2025. In 9M26, newly added 5G base stations stood at 416k units, vs. 454k units in 9M25, tracking at 77% of our estimate for new 5G base stations in 2026E (vs. 9M tracking at 71% of new 5G base stations in 2025). For macro 5G base stations, we expect to see 540k new 5G base stations in 2026E (vs. 588k new 5G base stations in 2025, per MIIT). China's telecom base station production was down 51% YoY in Sep 2026 (vs. -15% YoY in Aug 2026).

** Note that the MIIT changed its counting method for indoor 5G base stations from the number of Base Band Units (BBU) to the number of Remote Radio Units (RRU), leading to a much higher number from March 2023 to date compared with the same period in 2022.*

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Exhibit 1: We expect 540k 5G base stations to be added in 2026E

5G macro base stations in China	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E
Volume estimates	**150,000**	**620,000**	**654,000**	**887,000**	**1,065,000**	**874,000**	**588,000**	**540,000**	**500,000**
5G BTS on 2.1G/ 2.6G/ 3.5G/ 4.9G	150,000	620,000	454,000	437,000	565,000	574,000	338,000	340,000	350000
5G BTS on 700MHz/ 900MHz			200,000	450,000	500,000	300,000	250,000	200,000	150,000
Growth rate		313%	5%	36%	20%	-18%	-33%	-8%	-7%

Source: Company data, MIIT, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

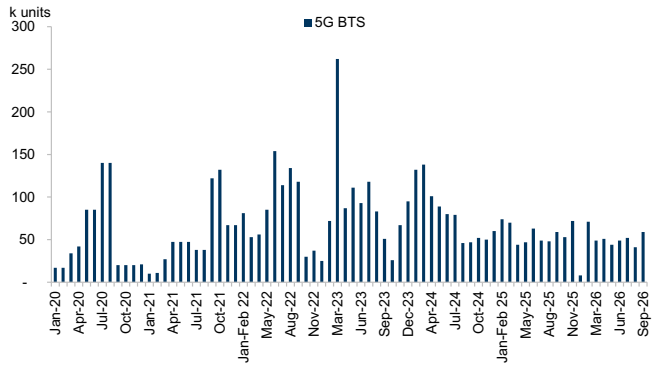
Base stations, fiber cable, CCL, and PCB growth mixed

For fiber cables, the key indicator is production volume, which includes shipments both locally and overseas. Sep 2026 fiber cable production was down 22% YoY, and the overseas export volumes were up 52% YoY in Sep 2026 (vs. +30% YoY in Aug 2026 vs. +56% YoY in Sep 2025).

- **Fiber cable export volumes were up 52% YoY in Sep 2026, and export value (in US dollar terms) increased by 561% YoY in Sep 2026.** The export volume of 4,867 tons in Sep 2026 (vs. 3,978 tons in Aug 2026) represents an increase in overseas demand.
- **Fiber cable production was down by 22% YoY in Sep 2026 (vs. -7% YoY in Aug 2026)**.
- **Fiber preform (a key raw material for fiber cables) import volumes were up 109% YoY** (vs. +80% MoM from Aug 2026) to 63 tons in Sep 2026 with a higher ASP (+57% MoM).
- **BTS export volumes decreased 56% YoY in Sep 2026, and the export value was down 42% YoY; export volumes were up 42% MoM, and export value was up by 5% MoM.** ASP was up by 42% MoM to US$7,219, up from Aug 2026.
- **China CCL (copper clad laminate) export prices were up by 116% YoY in Sep 2026 (or +14% MoM).** PCB export value increased 74% YoY; PCB net export value (exports minus imports) increased by 113% YoY in Sep 2026, compared to 60% in Aug 2026, representing the continued YoY growth momentum.
- **5G subscribers reached 1.3bn:** +8mn in Aug 2026 vs. +17mn in Aug 2025, per MIIT.
- **Taiwan telecom aggregate revenue was up 15% YoY to NT$53bn in Sep 2026** (aggregate revenue of Chunghwa Telecom, Far EasTone, and Taiwan Mobile).

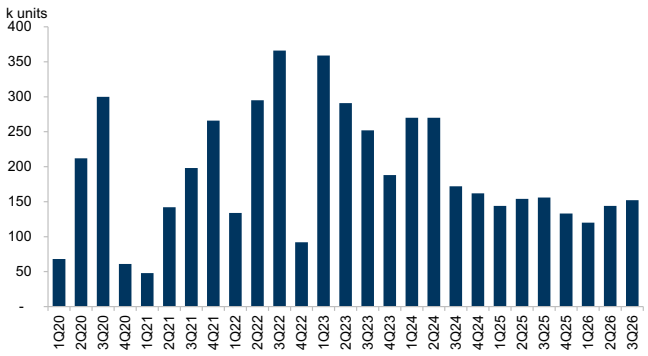
Unless otherwise noted, all production data is sourced from NBS, and trade data is sourced from China's General Administration of Customs.

Exhibit 2: Monthly new 5G base station additions: Sep 2026 deployment at 53k units, or 0% YoY



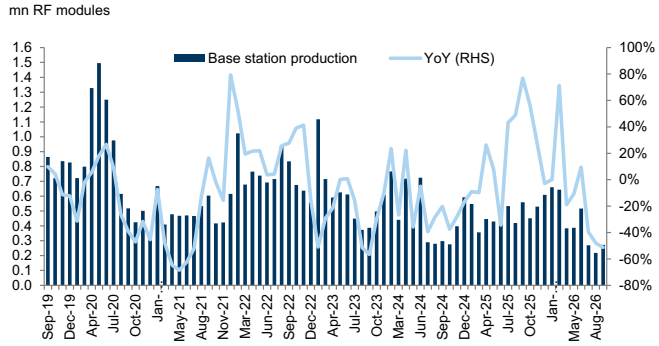
Source: MIIT

Exhibit 3: 5G base station deployment by quarter: 3Q26 deployment decreased QoQ



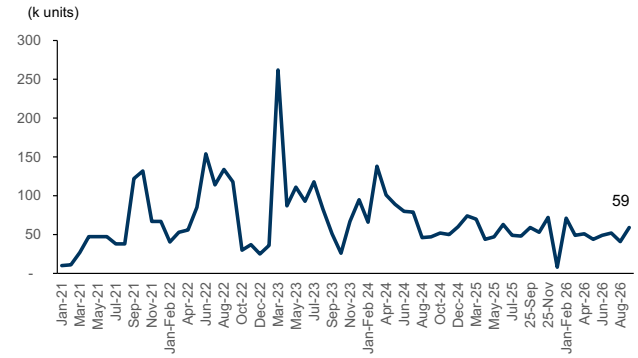
Source: MIIT

Exhibit 4: Base station production was -51% YoY in Sep 2026



Source: NBS

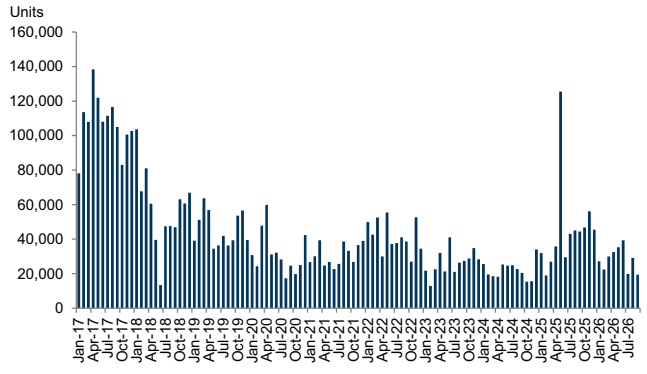
Exhibit 5: The number of newly installed 5G base stations in China was up to 59k units in Sep 2026 from 41k units in Aug 2026



* From Mar 23, 5G indoor base station numbers are estimated based on the number of Remote Radio Units (vs. counting based on the number of Base Band Units before).

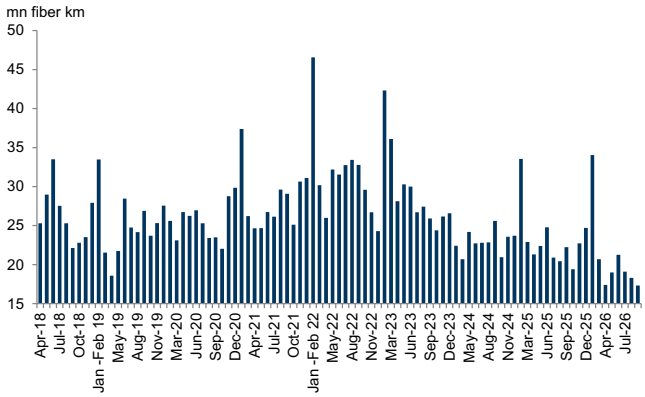
Source: MIIT

Exhibit 6: Sep 2026 base station export volumes were -56.3% YoY



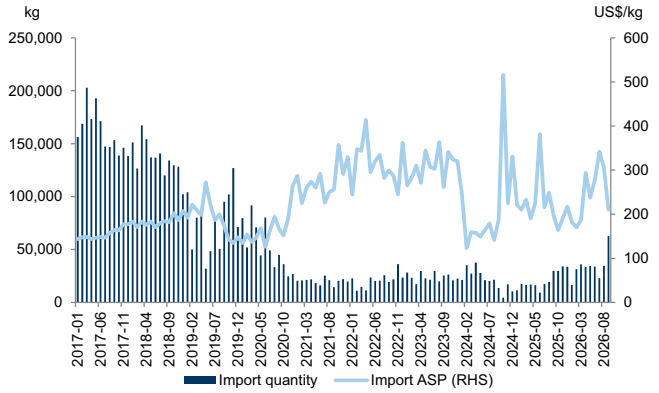
Source: China Customs

Exhibit 7: Fiber cable production was down 22% YoY in Sep 2026



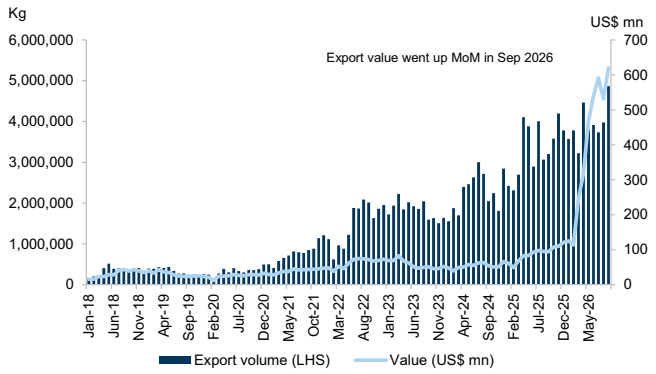
Source: NBS

Exhibit 8: Fiber preform import volume increased 80% MoM to 63 tons in Sep 2026



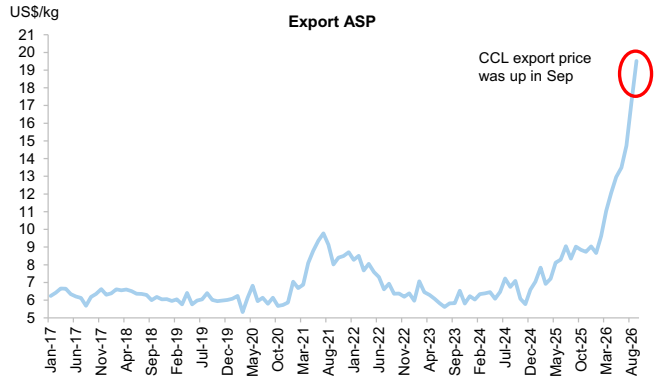
Source: China Customs

Exhibit 9: Fiber cable export volumes were up 22% MoM to 4,867 tons in Sep 2026



Source: China Customs

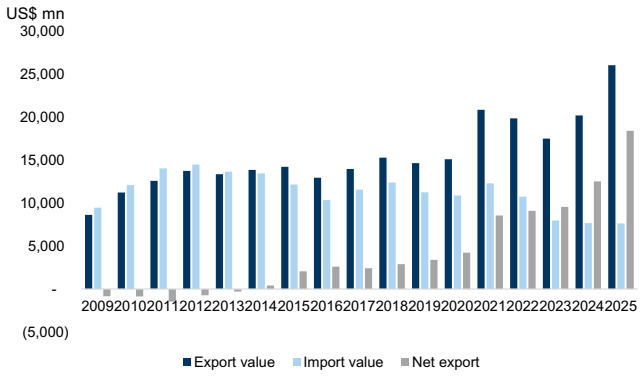
Exhibit 10: CCL export ASP increased 116% YoY or increased 14% MoM in Sep 2026



Source: China Customs

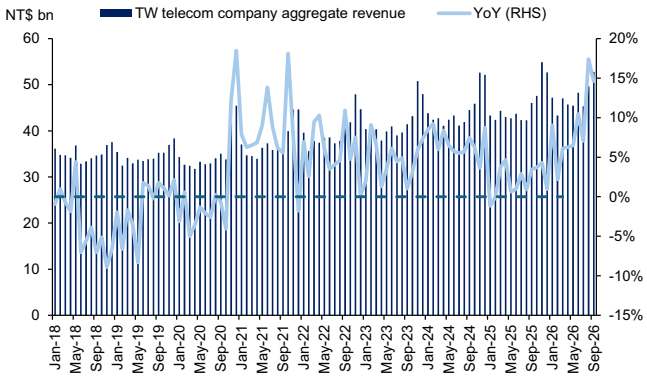
Exhibit 11: China's PCB net export volume is expected to rise as domestic PCB production capacity increases

PCB net exports were +47% in 2025



Source: China Customs

Exhibit 12: Major TW telecom companies' aggregate revenue was +15% YoY inSepr 2026 (vs. +17% YoY in Aug 2026)



Aggregate revenue of Chunghwa Telecom, Far EasTone, and Taiwan Mobile

Source: Company data

Exhibit 13: Telecom industry revenue and ARPU summary

	Aug-25	Sep-25	Oct-25	Nov-25	Dec-25	Feb-26 Jan+Feb	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26	Jul-26	Aug-26
Total telecom revenue (Rmb bn)	**139.0**	**144.9**	**140.0**	**142.6**	**140.4**	**290.4**	**149.0**	**154.7**	**141.4**	**151.8**	**132.7**	**140.0**
YoY	0.9%	2.0%	1.2%	1.0%	-3.4%	-1.6%	-1.9%	2.0%	-5.9%	-3.1%	-3.6%	0.7%
MoM	1.0%	4.2%	-3.4%	1.9%	-1.5%			3.8%	-8.6%	7.4%	-12.6%	5.5%
Mobile services												
Mobile data traffic (MB bn)	**33,400**	**34,000**	**35,800**	**35,500**	**37,100**	**66,670**	**37,730**	**37,600**	**39,200**	**38,500**	**39,000**	
YoY	17.2%	18.1%	18.5%	18.3%	19.7%	20.4%	17.0%	16.6%	16.0%	16.7%	17.1%	
DOU (MB/sub/mo) - reported	**20,870**	**21,230**	**22,210**	**22,000**	**23,040**	**19,310**	**23,400**	**23,170**	**24,010**	**23,570**	**23,810**	**23,450**
YoY	14.3%	15.5%	15.7%	15.1%	17.0%	16.1%	13.8%	13.4%	12.7%	13.6%	13.9%	12.4%
Mobile subs ('000)	**1,819,000**	**1,828,000**	**1,830,000**	**1,828,000**	**1,827,000**	**1,826,000**	**1,836,000**	**1,838,000**	**1,841,000**	**1,844,000**	**1,847,000**	
YoY	2.3%	2.4%	2.3%	2.1%	2.1%	1.8%	2.0%	1.9%	1.9%	1.9%	1.8%	
Fixed line services												
Fixed broadband subs ('000)	**688,680**	**694,690**	**696,840**	**701,886**	**691,000**	**694,000**	**697,000**	**698,000**				
YoY	4.4%	4.3%	4.3%	4.7%	3.2%	2.9%	2.8%	2.7%				
5G services												
5G uerss (mn)	**1,154.0**	**1,167.0**	**1,184.0**	**1,193.0**	**1,204.0**	**1,235.0**	**1,254.0**	**1,262.0**	**1,275.0**	**1,288.0**	**1,303.0**	**1,311.0**
Net add	**17.0**	**13.0**	**17.0**	**9.0**	**11.0**	**31.0**	**19.0**	**8.0**	**13.0**	**13.0**	**15.0**	**8.0**

Source: MIIT

Exhibit 14: China Telecom AI token plan

Enterprise version		
Package	**Fee (Rmb/ month)**	**Token usage/ month**
Basic	39.9	15m
Professional	159.9	70m
Flagship	299.9	150m
Personal version		
Package	**Fee (Rmb/ month)**	**Token usage/ month**
Lite	9.9	10m
Standard	29.9	40m
Premium	49.9	80m

Source: Company data

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Contributing Authors: Allen Chang Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Verena Jeng Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Ting Song Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C..

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